

2025 - Spring

Introduction to Leadership & Management for Engineers

Midterm

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Q1- In this case, after the acquisition, the company is facing several business and process-related problems, which are directly connected to the key concepts we studied in class.

Firstly, there is a serious level of organizational uncertainty. Employees don't know how promotion processes will work, whether investments will continue, or how the new structure will be implemented. This shows a lack of effective change management. As we learned, a leader must "dispel the fog" during times of uncertainty, offering a clear direction (Clausewitz's view on strategy). In this company, however, neither the direction nor the processes are transparent.

Secondly, a silo culture has developed inside the company. Internal competition for the GM position has led managers to operate in isolation with their teams, weakening collaboration across departments. This issue is related to team dynamics and communication management. As we discussed, effective leadership should prevent silos and encourage cross-functional trust and communication.

Thirdly, employees do not feel connected to the company's vision. Even though a strategic roadmap is written, they cannot see how their work contributes to it. This is linked to the concept of vision development and communication. A strong vision should be exciting, value-based, and easily understood across the organization.

Fourthly, there is a visible lack of trust. Employees rely more on rumors than on official messages. This reflects a failure in emotional and interpersonal leadership. According to the concept of emotional intelligence, leaders must show empathy, build open communication channels, and create a psychologically safe environment. Without these, employee engagement declines.

Finally, there is inconsistency in leadership styles among managers. Some are very controlling, while others are too relaxed. This issue relates to the situational leadership model. As we learned, different teams require different leadership styles (telling, selling, participating, delegating) depending on their level of readiness. In this case, that alignment is missing, which increases confusion.

Each of these problems is directly linked to a specific leadership or organizational concept:

– Organizational uncertainty → Change Management

– Lack of collaboration → Communication Management & Team Dynamics

– Disconnected vision → Vision Development

– Trust issues → Emotional Intelligence

– Inconsistent leadership → Situational Leadership Model

Recognizing these connections helps us better understand the root causes behind the symptoms described in the case.

Q2- To solve the problems in the case, the GM shouldn't stick to just one leadership style. Since there are many different issues like lack of vision, trust problems, and weak teamwork, the GM needs to use a mix of leadership models. The best choice is to combine emotional intelligence, Goleman's leadership styles, and the Hersey–Blanchard situational leadership model.

Firstly, the company has a vision on paper, but employees don't feel connected to it. Most of them don't know why they are working or what their work means for the company. For this, the GM should use Goleman's authoritative style. This style helps give clear direction and motivates people. The GM should explain the vision with simple and real examples so that everyone understands how their job supports the company's goals.

Secondly, the case shows there's a serious trust problem. People believe in rumors instead of official messages. This is where the affiliative style is helpful. It focuses on emotional connection and teamwork. The GM should listen to employees, talk openly, and create a safe and friendly work environment. That will help reduce gossip and build trust again.

Thirdly, different teams have different levels of readiness. Some need clear orders, while others can manage on their own. That's why the GM should use the Hersey–Blanchard situational leadership model:

For inexperienced teams → use telling (give clear instructions),

For unsure but willing teams → use selling (explain and convince),

For more confident teams → use participating (share decisions),

For experienced and motivated teams → use delegating (give responsibility).

Finally, for long-term improvement, the GM should also use coaching style. This means supporting managers one-on-one, giving feedback, and helping them grow their skills. It builds a stronger leadership system for the future.

In short, the GM must understand what each team needs and choose the right style for each situation. This is the best way to fix the problems in the company. And it is directly related to the concepts we learned like vision, emotional intelligence, and situational leadership.